So mine was a privileged upbringing, as a scion of a ruling class, rooted in the fact that six generations of the male members of my family chose to seek their fortunes in India, in occupations as varied as the Indian Civil Service (ICS), the Indian Army, indigo-planting and missionary work. Many were born in India, like myself and my parents before me, and at least a dozen that I know of lie in graves as far apart as Ali Masjid in the Khyber Pass and Colombo. The rest did their best to come Home – always implied with a capital 'H' if not actually spelled that way – to die in Cheltenham or thereabouts on modest pensions.

That elephant ride in the Assam jungle was over seventy years ago. In 1966 I was lucky enough to be posted by Voluntary Service Overseas to Nepal to teach English at a school outside Kathmandu. I'm not sure the boys I taught learned much but I did, because Nepal was then the last surviving Hindu monarchy on the subcontinent, as well as having the last surviving pocket of Mahayana Vajrayana Buddhism. Nepal was also where I met my future wife Liz, and since then she and I have been drawn back to the subcontinent time and time again, to criss-cross the country by whatever means were available to us, which now tends to be a comfy air-conditioned car with driver.

Ever since that first elephantine adventure of my childhood the notion of quest has had me hooked. Without quite knowing why, I have made pilgrimages to Kedarnath and Badrinath, dipped my head under the icy waters of the actual source of the Ganges at Gaumukh and at its legendary source in Lake Manasarovar, and completed *parikarama*s – circuits of holy places – of Mount Kailas and Kawa Karpo in far eastern Tibet, to say nothing of visiting thousands of Hindu *mandir*s and *kovil*s, Jain *basti*s, Sikh *gurdwaras* and Buddhist *stupas*, *vihara*s and rock-cut *chaitya*s. I can even claim to have completed the *char dham yatra* – pilgrimage to the four holiest abodes, of Badrinath, Dwaraka, Puri and Rameshwaram – though more by chance